

Riding HIGH

The Congress is sitting pretty, looking to buck the anti-incumbency factor and sweep the Assembly polls

The Congress is on a roll. After announcing the names of all its candidates at one go, even before nominations opened, Chief Minister Y.S. Rajasekhara Reddy hit the campaign trail to touch 170 of the 294 constituencies before polling begins in April. Performance inspired by development initiatives is what Reddy is banking on to emerge as a winner and has emboldened the Congress to go it alone for the first time. "No other state in the country has implemented the welfare and development programmes that we have," says Reddy at various meetings.

Apart from performing, his team also analyses the social matrix and the strengths and weaknesses in every constituency to make course corrections as a part of the strategy of fielding "winnable" contestants. For this, the Congress has dropped 53 of the 185 sitting MLAs and, in spite of protests, Reddy has placated them, promising "recognition in due course". Never has the Congress gone to the polls with such confidence since the rise of the TDP in

1982. Incumbency is to his advantage like it has been for Narendra Modi, Sheila Dikshit and Shivraj Singh Chouhan. Now, the Congress is more likely to win the Assembly polls for the second time in a row which the party has not done since 1978.

fray the edges. Naidu has agreed to give the TRS 45 assembly constituencies—three more than what the Congress conceded in 2004—and nine Lok Sabha constituencies. The communists, piggybacking on the other two, have been allotted 30 Assembly and four Lok Sabha constituencies. It has left the TDP with 219 of the 294 Assembly and 29 of the 42 Lok Sabha constituencies in the state and he needs to win a majority of those if he is to become a force to reckon with, both in regional and national politics. He is clearly the meat in the electoral



'Mee Kosam' yatra to showcase his concern for the poor, the farming community and the need for balanced development of the countryside. What it also showed was that his desire to be the chief minister again remains the priority but he is still unsure whether his makeover has convinced the state's 5.67 crore voters that his Telugu Desam Party (TDP) has the cutting edge to win the 2009 Assembly and Lok Sabha polls. Hence the alliance and the new image. Naidu has already set the record for being the

longest serving chief minister the state has ever seen, and the new alliance perhaps represents his last desperate bid to extend that record further. Moreover, he is hoping that post-election 2009, he will be able to play a pivotal role in choosing the next prime minister from a party other than the Congress and BJP.

That could be a tad optimistic. Though the Grand Alliance announced in mid-January has taken some shape, the inherent differences and priorities are already starting to

sandwich but now faces a multi-cornered contest and has had to switch electoral strategy. The lack of preparedness for the emerging entity, filmstar Chiranjeevi's Praja Rajyam Party (PRP), foiled any chance of an electoral understanding and forced Naidu to announce, in a volte face, that his party is for a separate Telangana and to form an alliance against the Congress and PRP.

Unfortunately, the initial misgivings on constituency-sharing have deepened apprehensions about a con-